ENGLISH C2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Nominal packaging and grammatical metaphor

Recast processes and qualities as noun groups to build abstraction while monitoring agency, time and logical transparency. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use nominal packaging and grammatical metaphor to compress complex relations into discourse objects that can be classified, compared and referred to while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Recast processes and qualities as noun groups to build abstraction while monitoring agency, time and logical transparency.

MODEL

The committee's rejection of the proposal prompted a reassessment.

clause process + participants -> nominal group + complements

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main nominal packaging and grammatical metaphor patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses compress complex relations into discourse objects that can be classified, compared and referred to.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in advanced academic, policy and technical writing.

Build meaning before form

Recast processes and qualities as noun groups to build abstraction while monitoring agency, time and logical transparency.

What nominal packaging and grammatical metaphor communicates

Recast processes and qualities as noun groups to build abstraction while monitoring agency, time and logical transparency.

The central purpose is to compress complex relations into discourse objects that can be classified, compared and referred to. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

The committee's rejection of the proposal prompted a reassessment.	an event packaged as a noun while both participants remain visible
The instability of the estimate limits its usefulness.	a quality treated as an object of evaluation
A reduction in staffing led to an increase in processing time.	two processes packaged as comparable entities

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: clause process + participants -> nominal group + complements. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model "The committee's rejection of the proposal prompted a reassessment." shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Process nominalisation	possessive/of-agent + action noun + of-object	The committee's rejection of the proposal prompted a reassessment.
Quality nominalisation	abstract quality noun + complement	The instability of the estimate limits its usefulness.
Condensed relation	nominal groups linked by preposition	A reduction in staffing led to an increase in processing time.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
an event packaged as a noun while both participants remain visible	Process nominalisation
a quality treated as an object of evaluation	Quality nominalisation
two processes packaged as comparable entities	Condensed relation

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in advanced academic, policy and technical writing. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03
clause process	participants -> nominal group	complements

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: compress complex relations into discourse objects that can be classified, compared and referred to.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits advanced academic, policy and technical writing.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Process nominalisation	possessive/of-agent + action noun + of-object	The committee's rejection of the proposal prompted a reassessment.
Quality nominalisation	abstract quality noun + complement	The instability of the estimate limits its usefulness.
Condensed relation	nominal groups linked by preposition	A reduction in staffing led to an increase in processing time.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

The committee's rejection of the proposal prompted a reassessment.	an event packaged as a noun while both participants remain visible
The instability of the estimate limits its usefulness.	a quality treated as an object of evaluation
A reduction in staffing led to an increase in processing time.	two processes packaged as comparable entities

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not hide the responsible participant when it is analytically important.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Avoid abstract noun chains that make the logical relationship hard to recover.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Check that nominal compression has not removed time or causal direction.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: an event packaged as a noun while both participants remain visible?

OPTIONS The committee's rejection of the proposal prompted a reassessment. · The instability of the estimate limits its usefulness. · A reduction in staffing led to an increase in processing time.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a quality treated as an object of evaluation?

OPTIONS The instability of the estimate limits its usefulness. · A reduction in staffing led to an increase in processing time. · The committee's rejection of the proposal prompted a reassessment.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: two processes packaged as comparable entities?

OPTIONS A reduction in staffing led to an increase in processing time. · The committee's rejection of the proposal prompted a reassessment. · The instability of the estimate limits its usefulness.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does "The committee's rejection of the proposal prompted a reassessment." communicate in this context?

OPTIONS an event packaged as a noun while both participants remain visible · a quality treated as an object of evaluation · two processes packaged as comparable entities

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does "The instability of the estimate limits its usefulness." communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a quality treated as an object of evaluation · two processes packaged as comparable entities · an event packaged as a noun while both participants remain visible

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does "A reduction in staffing led to an increase in processing time." communicate in this context?

OPTIONS two processes packaged as comparable entities · an event packaged as a noun while both participants remain visible · a quality treated as an object of evaluation

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

"The committee's rejection of the proposal prompted a reassessment." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Process nominalisation / Quality nominalisation / Condensed relation · Gap 2: an event packaged as a noun while both participants remain visible / a quality treated as an object of evaluation / two processes packaged as comparable entities

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

"The instability of the estimate limits its usefulness." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Quality nominalisation / Condensed relation / Process nominalisation · Gap 2: a quality treated as an object of evaluation / two processes packaged as comparable entities / an event packaged as a noun while both participants remain visible

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

"A reduction in staffing led to an increase in processing time." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Condensed relation / Process nominalisation / Quality nominalisation · Gap 2: two processes packaged as comparable entities / an event packaged as a noun while both participants remain visible / a quality treated as an object of evaluation

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses an event packaged as a noun while both participants remain visible: _____. Choose the model that expresses a quality treated as an object of evaluation: _____. Choose the model that expresses two processes packaged as comparable entities: _____. Choose the model built with possessive/of-agent + action noun + of-object: _____. Choose the model built with abstract quality noun + complement: _____. Choose the model built with nominal groups linked by preposition: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

A reduction in staffing led to an increase in processing time. · The committee's rejection of the proposal prompted a reassessment. · The instability of the estimate limits its usefulness.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

The committee's _____ prompted a reassessment. The _____ limits its usefulness. A _____ led to an increase in processing time. State the full structural pattern for Process nominalisation: _____. State the full structural pattern for Quality nominalisation: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “The committee rejected the proposal, so the team reassessed it.” using the Process nominalisation pattern to express an event packaged as a noun while both participants remain visible.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “Because the estimate is unstable, it is less useful.” using the Quality nominalisation pattern to express a quality treated as an object of evaluation.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “Staffing fell, so processing took longer.” using the Condensed relation pattern to express two processes packaged as comparable entities.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “The committee rejected the proposal, so the team reassessed it.” using the Process nominalisation pattern to express an event packaged as a noun while both participants remain visible.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Process nominalisation to express an event packaged as a noun while both participants remain visible, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Quality nominalisation to express a quality treated as an object of evaluation, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Condensed relation to express two processes packaged as comparable entities, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

The committee’s rejection of the proposal prompted a reassessment.

Process nominalisation is the best match because an event packaged as a noun while both participants remain visible.

A2

The instability of the estimate limits its usefulness.

Quality nominalisation is the best match because a quality treated as an object of evaluation.

A3

A reduction in staffing led to an increase in processing time.

Condensed relation is the best match because two processes packaged as comparable entities.

A4

an event packaged as a noun while both participants remain visible

The Process nominalisation pattern communicates an event packaged as a noun while both participants remain visible.

A5

a quality treated as an object of evaluation

The Quality nominalisation pattern communicates a quality treated as an object of evaluation.

A6

two processes packaged as comparable entities

The Condensed relation pattern communicates two processes packaged as comparable entities.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Process nominalisation / an event packaged as a noun while both participants remain visible

The structure belongs to the Process nominalisation pattern. Its communicative purpose is an event packaged as a noun while both participants remain visible.

B2

Quality nominalisation / a quality treated as an object of evaluation

The structure belongs to the Quality nominalisation pattern. Its communicative purpose is a quality treated as an object of evaluation.

B3

Condensed relation / two processes packaged as comparable entities

The structure belongs to the Condensed relation pattern. Its communicative purpose is two processes packaged as comparable entities.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

The committee’s rejection of the proposal prompted a reassessment.

Process nominalisation: possessive/of-agent + action noun + of-object.

C2

The instability of the estimate limits its usefulness.

Quality nominalisation: abstract quality noun + complement.

C3

A reduction in staffing led to an increase in processing time.

Condensed relation: nominal groups linked by preposition.

C4

The committee’s rejection of the proposal prompted a reassessment.

Process nominalisation: possessive/of-agent + action noun + of-object.

C5

The instability of the estimate limits its usefulness.

Quality nominalisation: abstract quality noun + complement.

C6

A reduction in staffing led to an increase in processing time.

Condensed relation: nominal groups linked by preposition.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

rejection of the proposal

Process nominalisation requires “rejection of the proposal” in this model. possessive/of-agent + action noun + of-object.

D2

instability of the estimate

Quality nominalisation requires “instability of the estimate” in this model. abstract quality noun + complement.

D3

reduction in staffing

Condensed relation requires “reduction in staffing” in this model. nominal groups linked by preposition.

D4

possessive/of-agent + action noun + of-object

Process nominalisation is built as possessive/of-agent + action noun + of-object.

D5

abstract quality noun + complement

Quality nominalisation is built as abstract quality noun + complement.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The committee’s rejection of the proposal prompted a reassessment.

possessive/of-agent + action noun + of-object. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended process nominalisation effect.

E2

The instability of the estimate limits its usefulness.

abstract quality noun + complement. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended quality nominalisation effect.

E3

A reduction in staffing led to an increase in processing time.

nominal groups linked by preposition. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended condensed relation effect.

E4

The committee’s rejection of the proposal prompted a reassessment.

possessive/of-agent + action noun + of-object. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended process nominalisation effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

The committee’s rejection of the proposal prompted a reassessment. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses possessive/of-agent + action noun + of-object accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

The instability of the estimate limits its usefulness. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses abstract quality noun + complement accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

A reduction in staffing led to an increase in processing time. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses nominal groups linked by preposition accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____